

INDIA AND THE NEIGHBOURHOOD

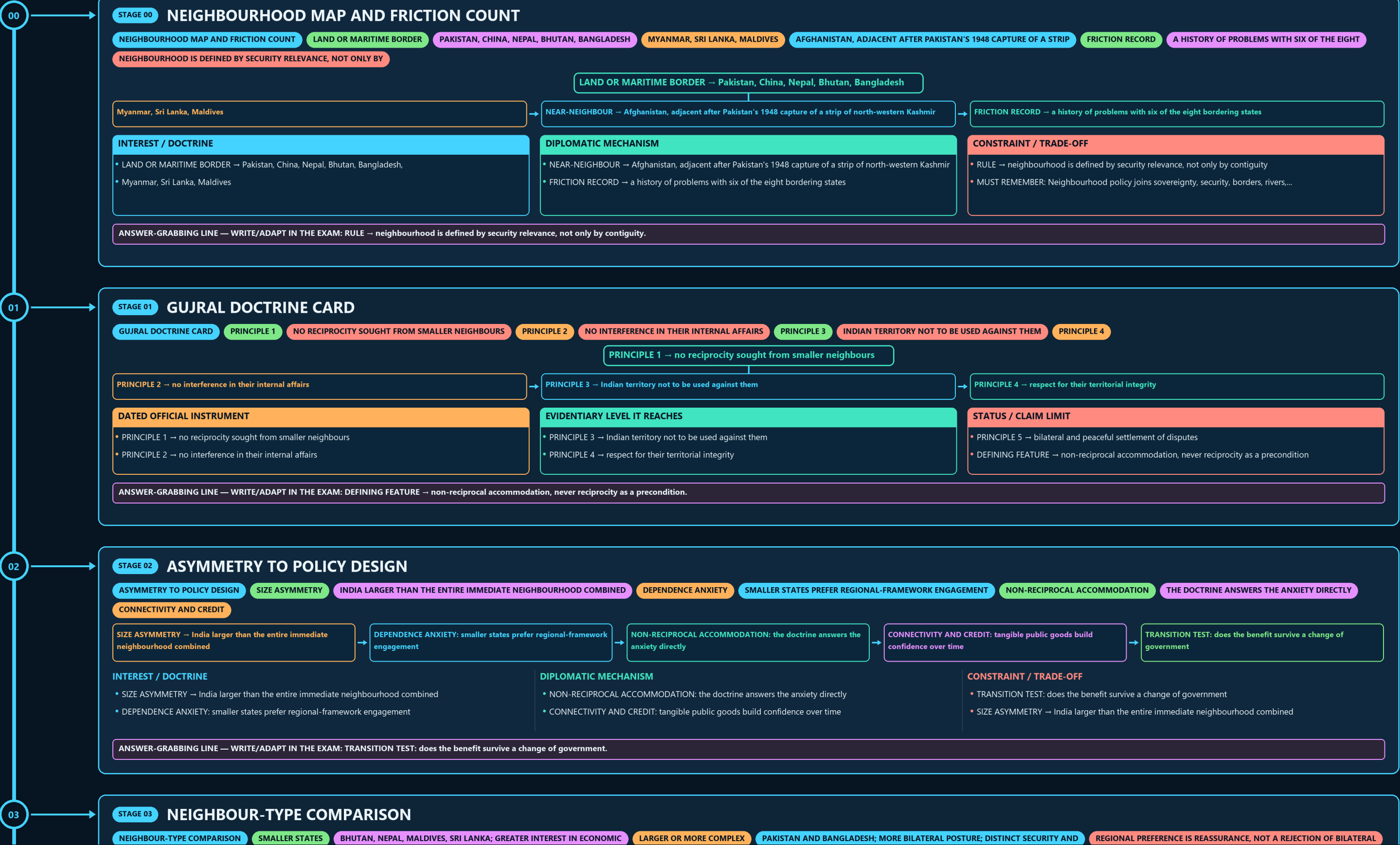
NEIGHBOURHOOD MAP AND FRICTION → GUJRAL DOCTRINE CARD → ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN → NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON → CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER → DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g4 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles



02

STAGE 02

ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGN

ASYMMETRY TO POLICY DESIGNSIZE ASYMMETRYINDIA LARGER THAN THE ENTIRE IMMEDIATE NEIGHBOURHOOD COMBINEDDEPENDENCE ANXIETYSMALLER STATES PREFER REGIONAL-FRAMEWORK ENGAGEMENTNON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATIONTHE DOCTRINE ANSWERS THE ANXIETY DIRECTLY

CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT

SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement

NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly

CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time

TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined
- DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly
- CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government
- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government.

03

STAGE 03

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISONSMALLER STATESBHUTAN, NEPAL, MALDIVES, SRI LANKA; GREATER INTEREST IN ECONOMICLARGER OR MORE COMPLEXPAKISTAN AND BANGLADESH; MORE BILATERAL POSTURE; DISTINCT SECURITY ANDREGIONAL PREFERENCE IS REASSURANCE, NOT A REJECTION OF BILATERAL

03

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined
- DEPENDENCE ANXIETY: smaller states prefer regional-framework engagement

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- NON-RECIPROCAL ACCOMMODATION: the doctrine answers the anxiety directly
- CONNECTIVITY AND CREDIT: tangible public goods build confidence over time

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government
- SIZE ASYMMETRY → India larger than the entire immediate neighbourhood combined

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRANSITION TEST: does the benefit survive a change of government.

04

STAGE 03

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

NEIGHBOUR-TYPE COMPARISON

SMALLER STATES

BHUTAN, NEPAL, MALDIVES, SRI LANKA; GREATER INTEREST IN ECONOMIC

LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX

PAKISTAN AND BANGLADESH; MORE BILATERAL POSTURE; DISTINCT SECURITY AND

REGIONAL PREFERENCE IS REASSURANCE, NOT A REJECTION OF BILATERAL

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka	regional framework preferred because numbers give a sense of security	QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery
greater interest in economic integration	LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX → Pakistan and Bangladesh; more bilateral posture; distinct security and historical dynamics	SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

ACTOR / INTEREST

- SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka
- greater interest in economic integration

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- regional framework preferred because numbers give a sense of security
- LARGER OR MORE COMPLEX → Pakistan and Bangladesh; more bilateral posture; distinct security and historical dynamics

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery
- SMALLER STATES → Bhutan, Nepal, Maldives, Sri Lanka

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: QUALIFIER → regional preference is reassurance, not a rejection of bilateral delivery.

05

STAGE 04

CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER

CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT LEDGER

1 NOVEMBER 2023

AKHAURA-AGARTALA CROSS-BORDER RAIL LINK INAUGURATED

BBIN MOTOR VEHICLES AGREEMENT SIGNED; BHUTAN NON-RATIFICATION CONSTRAINS IT

720 MW MANGDECHHU COMMISSIONED, THEN HANDED OVER TO BHUTAN

MAY 2023

KALADAN WATERWAY AND SITTWE PORT OPERATIONALISED; ROAD COMPONENT LAGGED

1 JUNE 2026

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
1 NOVEMBER 2023 → Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link inaugurated	2019 / 2022 → 720 MW Mangdechhu commissioned, then handed over to Bhutan	1 JUNE 2026 → both sides still calling for Kaladan completion
2015 → BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement signed; Bhutan non-ratification constrains it	MAY 2023 → Kaladan waterway and Sittwe Port operationalised; road component lagged	RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed

ACTOR / INTEREST

- 1 NOVEMBER 2023 → Akhaura-Agartala cross-border rail link inaugurated
- 2015 → BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement signed; Bhutan non-ratification constrains it

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- 2019 / 2022 → 720 MW Mangdechhu commissioned, then handed over to Bhutan
- MAY 2023 → Kaladan waterway and Sittwe Port operationalised; road component lagged

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 1 JUNE 2026 → both sides still calling for Kaladan completion
- RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → the gap is segment delivered against corridor completed.

06

STAGE 05

DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

DATED BILATERAL INSTRUMENT MATRIX

SRI LANKA

SEVEN MOUS, 5 APRIL 2025; BRIEF CURRENT TO JULY

JOINT VISION 7 OCTOBER 2024; FTA TERMS OF REFERENCE

INR 4,850 CRORE LINE OF CREDIT; BRIEF CURRENT TO

INR 100 BILLION FOR THE 13TH FIVE YEAR PLAN

2025; GELEPHU MINDFULNESS CITY SUPPORT 12 NOVEMBER 2025

VISION, TERMS OF REFERENCE, MEMORANDUM AND CREDIT ARE PRE-DELIVERY

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
SRI LANKA → seven MoUs, 5 April 2025; brief current to July 2026; Sampur 120 MW had ground-breaking, not commissioning	INR 4,850 crore line of credit; brief current to June 2026	2025; Gelephu Mindfulness City support 12 November 2025
MALDIVES → Joint Vision 7 October 2024; FTA Terms of Reference 25 July 2025	BHUTAN → INR 100 billion for the 13th Five Year Plan 2024-29; rail MoU 29 September	LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

ACTOR / INTEREST

- SRI LANKA → seven MoUs, 5 April 2025; brief current to July 2026; Sampur 120 MW had ground-breaking, not commissioning
- MALDIVES → Joint Vision 7 October 2024; FTA Terms of Reference 25 July 2025

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- INR 4,850 crore line of credit; brief current to June 2026
- BHUTAN → INR 100 billion for the 13th Five Year Plan 2024-29; rail MoU 29 September

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 2025; Gelephu Mindfulness City support 12 November 2025
- LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments.

06

STAGE 06

SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD

SRI LANKA 2022 FIRST-RESPONDER CARD

BY 3 MAY 2022

MORE THAN USD 3 BILLION RECORDED IN ASSISTANCE DURING

USD 1 BILLION

FACILITY FOR FOOD, MEDICINES AND ESSENTIALS

USD 500 MILLION

PETROLEUM CREDIT LINE; CLOSE TO 400,000 TONNES OF FUEL

ABOUT USD 1 BILLION

ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
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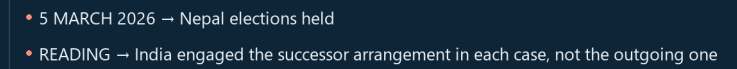
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- LEVEL → vision, terms of reference, memorandum and credit are pre-delivery instruments

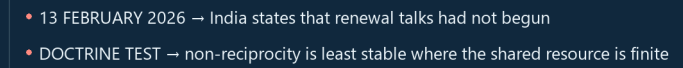
ABOUT USD 1 BILLION

- USD 400 million → Reserve Bank of India currency swap; 25 districts covered
- LIMIT → around USD 4 billion is the full-year description; structural problems remained

12 FEBRUARY 2026



DECEMBER 2026



NEGOTIATIONS LAUNCHED; NOT A CONCLUDED FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

- CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing...
- ABEYANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination

09

STAGE 09 STATUS DISTINCTIONS THAT DECIDE CLOSE OPTIONS

- STATUS DISTINCTIONS THAT DECIDE CLOSE OPTIONS
- AN EXECUTIVE DECISION ON OPERATION; EXPRESSLY NOT TREATY TERMINATION
- UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025
- TO STOP ALL MILITARY ACTIVITIES; NOT A CEASEFIRE AGREEMENT
- EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025
- MISSION LEVEL CHANGED; NO RECOGNITION DECLARATION
- TERMS OF REFERENCE
- NEGOTIATIONS LAUNCHED; NOT A CONCLUDED FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

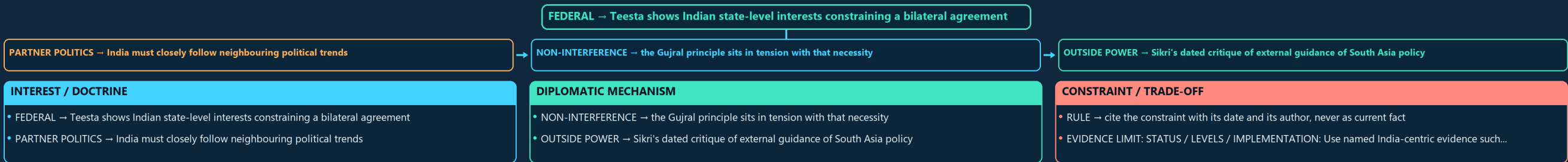
ACTOR / INTEREST	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT
ABEVANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination	EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration	CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing...
UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement	TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement	ABEVANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination
ACTOR / INTEREST • ABEVANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination • UNDERSTANDING OF 10 MAY 2025 → to stop all military activities; not a ceasefire agreement	DECISIVE DISTINCTION • EMBASSY UPGRADE OF 21 OCTOBER 2025 → mission level changed; no recognition declaration • TERMS OF REFERENCE → negotiations launched; not a concluded free trade agreement	STATUS TRAP / LIMIT • CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing... • ABEVANCE → an executive decision on operation; expressly not treaty termination

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE DISTINCTION: Treaty text, political understanding, project announcement, financing.

10

STAGE 10 DOMESTIC AND EXTERNAL CONSTRAINT BAND

- DOMESTIC AND EXTERNAL CONSTRAINT BAND
- TEESTA SHOWS INDIAN STATE-LEVEL INTERESTS CONSTRAINING A BILATERAL AGREEMENT
- PARTNER POLITICS
- INDIA MUST CLOSELY FOLLOW NEIGHBOURING POLITICAL TRENDS
- THE GUJRAL PRINCIPLE SITS IN TENSION WITH THAT NECESSITY
- OUTSIDE POWER
- SIKRI'S DATED CRITIQUE OF EXTERNAL GUIDANCE OF SOUTH ASIA
- CITE THE CONSTRAINT WITH ITS DATE AND ITS AUTHOR

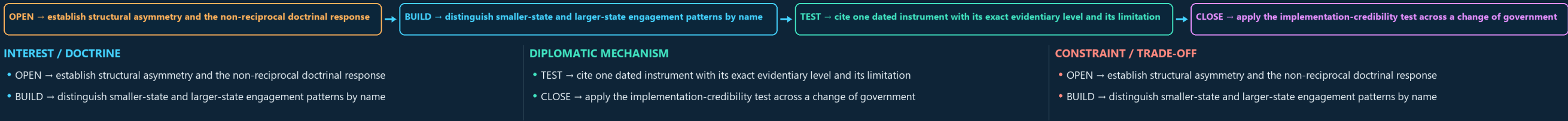


ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → cite the constraint with its date and its author, never as current fact.

11

STAGE 11 ANSWER SPINE FOR A NEIGHBOURHOOD DEMAND

- ANSWER SPINE FOR A NEIGHBOURHOOD DEMAND
- ESTABLISH STRUCTURAL ASYMMETRY AND THE NON-RECIPROCAL DOCTRINAL RESPONSE
- DISTINGUISH SMALLER-STATE AND LARGER-STATE ENGAGEMENT PATTERNS BY NAME
- CITE ONE DATED INSTRUMENT WITH ITS EXACT EVIDENTIARY LEVEL
- APPLY THE IMPLEMENTATION-CREDIBILITY TEST ACROSS A CHANGE OF GOVERNMENT



ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → apply the implementation-credibility test across a change of government.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

- OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT
- BILATERAL SUMMIT-LEVEL MECHANISMS (ANNUAL OR PERIODIC LEADER-LEVEL)
- MEA BILATERAL BRIEFS (INDIA-SRI LANKA AND INDIA-BHUTAN, CURRENT TO
- POWER-GRID AND TRANSIT PROTOCOLS ARE TYPICALLY NEGOTIATED AND RENEWED
- REGIONAL-FRAMEWORK OVERLAY (SAARC, BIMSTEC) PROVIDES THE MULTILATERAL
- BOUNDARY CASE — HISTORICAL INTERVENTION VS. STATED NON-INTERFERENCE
- BOUNDARY CASE — SMALLER-STATE HEDGING
- EVEN NEIGHBOURS THAT VALUE

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE AND INSTRUMENT DEPTH

- CAUTION: Bilateral summit-level mechanisms (annual or periodic leader-level
- MEA bilateral briefs (India-Sri Lanka and India-Bhutan, current to July
- CAUTION: Power-grid and transit protocols are typically negotiated and renewed
- CAUTION: Regional-framework overlay (SAARC, BIMSTEC) provides the multilateral

STATUS, DATE AND FIGURE LIMIT

- CAUTION: Boundary case — historical intervention vs. stated non-interference:
- CAUTION: Boundary case — smaller-state hedging: even neighbours that value
- CAUTION: Boundary case — Afghanistan as a near-neighbour: Tharoor's inclusion of
- CAUTION: Regime change discontinuity risk: any government transition in a

COMPARATIVE DIPLOMATIC NUANCE

- CAUTION: Boundary case — the implementation-credibility test with dated
- CAUTION: Non-reciprocity has fiscal and political cost: the Gujral Doctrine's
- CAUTION: Regional-framework preference vs. bilateral delivery tension: smaller
- CAUTION: Domestic political engagement vs. non-interference principle: the need

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.